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# TED Comes to India

**Q** This is the first time TED has come to Asia. How was India chosen as the location?

**A** TED, as an organisation is interested in getting more global voices. When we conduct events in the US, most of the participants come from the western hemisphere. But if you really want to get more thought on what's happening in the world, you got to listen to what they have to say (the nations). If you consider the world's most populous countries, six of them are in Asia. In fact, between India and China we have one-fifth of the world's population. There are a lot of things happening in Asia that are clearly of interest. Within that, India is the microcosm of the future because of the young population. Definitely, if you want to know the future, you should go to where the future lives.

**Q** How has the experience been and what kind of response has TEDIndia 2009 received?

**A** We were very happy with the response. We had a lot of companies that financially supported us, and a lot of participation from all over the world. Lots of Indians coming here, from something like 46 different countries. We were targeting around 400 people, and we had over 900 people who came. We got really good feedback at the end — a lot of people felt this was one of the most fun TEDs and it was great at showcasing what's going on in this part of the world.

**Q** What are the plans for the future? Any more events or conferences soon?

**A** We have a very good product strategy in India. Some meets are independently organised events. They are not editorialised by TED. Twenty TEDx events are already queued up. These are independent events, where the organisers get to share some of the credit. It is hard for

an organisation to have three conferences in a year and be true to the brand. But we have a lot of other activities planned, and there are many ways in which India could participate on our global stage. We are working on a lot of those ideas.

**Q** How can people be a part of TEDx events?

**A** Well, there is a whole licencing process. If you go to the web site, you can have a look at the process. There are rules on how many people you can have, that you cannot charge, that the sponsorship has to cover the costs as this is not a money making conference. The whole idea is that we have all these videos, and how we can make sure people can see them. They can be shown at parties, or schools and colleges, there is just so much that can be done, to take content that already exists to inspire people.

**Q** Are you looking at the smaller cities and towns in India as well?

**A** Certainly, There is a woman who flits between Dubai and India, who is organising one in a small village in Rajasthan, which is about three-four hours away from Jaipur. One person is holding one in a very small place in Karnataka. It is being spread all across, not only in metropolitan cities.

**Q** If our readers want to make a presentation, how do they go about it?

**A** Typically, we read the mails that are sent to us very carefully. Based on what comes to us, we decide on how to take it further. But the fact is that if a person comes to our notice with some credibility, from a path that we can trust, or somebody we know can vouch for their work, it just makes it a little easier. That does not mean this is the only way. We always encourage people to send in their ideas to



**Lakshmi Pratury, co-host, TEDIndia 2009 spoke to Digit on TED's first Asian conference, TED's plans for India and its various global activities**

us, then we figure out what makes sense and what fits in. There is an overall structure to our selection. We are looking for an equal amount of artists, architects, scientists, social entrepreneurs, etc. We try to maintain that variety.

**Q** How do people attend a conference?

**A** We have an application process. People have to answer a few questions. We get back to them, on whether they were accepted or not, then they pay to get in. The reason we do that because we want to have a mix of audience. We got in a hundred TEDIndia fellows completely for free, because we felt we needed to have that youth element, and the inability to pay should not be a reason for deserving people not to be there. We try to make sure as many people from a wide variety of backgrounds can get in to the conference, at the same time ensuring that we can continue to provide the content that we do for free. **Q**